



TIME TO UPGRADE

With a history spanning centuries, let's take a look how the watch stayed relevant by becoming smarter and what's in store for the future.

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A watch was probably the first piece of technology I ever owned in my life. I must have been six or seven and I pestered my parents into getting it for me. It was one of those really cheap digital watches from a store in Sarojini Nagar in New Delhi. But I didn't care. It was MINE. I was free to fiddle with it as much as I wanted to. It is possible that watch ignited the spark that led to an interest in tech, which later snowballed into my present career.

The term 'wearable tech' is such a wide field when you think about it. The classic Sony Walkman is technically wearable tech as you can clip it to your belt. So are VR/AR glasses. That cool action camera you got that clips on to your helmet. Yup, wearable tech. To keep things simple, we'll mostly be talking about smartwatches and fitness trackers here. This will help ensure that I don't end up hogging the entire magazine.

BABY STEPS TOWARDS THE SMARTWATCH

The idea of a high-tech gadget has been a pretty consistent part of science fiction. Which is probably what spurred engineers to try and make it a reality. The most famous example is probably Dick Tracy's radio watch that allowed our titular hero to com-

municate with his team. Another famous example is from Knight Rider, where Michael Knight (played by David Hasselhoff no less) has a high tech wrist watch that can take photographs, scan areas and more. It could also be used to communicate with K.I.T.T., the high-tech car that was arguably the main star.

20 years ago, the smartwatch as we know it wasn't exactly there. But that doesn't mean companies didn't dabble with the technology even before that. If you look far enough, you can see how companies individually developed key aspects of the technology. But tech miniaturisation just wasn't at the levels where everything could be crammed into one tiny device that fit on your wrist.



Timex Datalink

Credit: Dr K



Casio TC500 Calculator Watch

Credit: Binarysequence

The first key step to the smartwatches we know today happened all the way back in 1972, a full five years before Star Wars: A New Hope was released. The Hamilton Watch Company launched the Pulsar Time Computer, the first watch with no moving parts at all. You see, before this, watches had physical moving parts in them like watch hands or gears. But the Pulsar was entirely digital. You press a button and a digital display would light up to tell you the time. In short, a computer was now small enough to wear on your wrist. Ladies and gentlemen, this was Genesis!